



Roll of honour: Pawan Sen with some of his most accomplished proteges, including Harleen Deol, Renuka Singh Thakur (right), Sushma Verma and Tanuja Kanwer (extreme left). SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

convinced the association to move the academy from Kangra to the main stadium in Dharamsala. But the bigger test still lay ahead.

Himachal's terrain and climate have ingrained a sense of resource management into everyday life.

Cricket is no different.

Anything done has to be worth doing. Starting a women's residential academy was a novel

initiative, but it had to be backed by results.

"There was a girls' academy here and a boys' academy in Una. Anurag [Thakur] ji gave us three years. He said, 'Show me you can perform, and I will scale up this operation.' He told the same to the boys' academy. In the third year, I told the team that this is your final chance. *Agar yahan se ghar vaapis chale gaye, toh*

cricket khatam hai aapki (If you go back home now, your cricket ambitions will be over). But the girls did so well that everything changed after that," Sen says.

Sen coached the Himachal Pradesh U-19 women's team to the North Zone final against Punjab. Almost the entire team had trained under him in Dharamsala.

"The level of our cricket improved a lot in a short span because all of us used to practise together. If 20-25 girls practise together and then they play games together, a good bond is formed. The communication is good. So, we benefited a lot from that. Our team was very good," Tanuja says.

Himachal lost the final, but Sen found another student who would blaze a trail to the Indian team.

"Harleen was not getting enough playing time in the Punjab team. Her

« In 17 years, the HPCA residential academy has produced four India internationals: Sushma Verma, Harleen Deol, Renuka Singh Thakur, and Tanuja Kanwer »